Amai Pakpak Medical Center

Amai Pakpak Medical Center (APMC), known in Filipino as *Sentrong Medikal ng Amai Pakpak*, is a government-owned tertiary teaching and training hospital in Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). It is retained and directly funded by the national Department of Health (DOH), and it holds the distinction of being Mindanao's designated regional apex multi-specialty referral center, the hospital where the region's toughest cases, from complicated heart conditions to advanced cancers, eventually land when smaller facilities run out of options.

What makes APMC's story worth telling isn't just its size or its services. It's the sheer number of times this hospital has had to start over. It has burned down, been fought over during one of the deadliest urban battles in recent Philippine history, and still managed to open a full cardiac surgery program less than a decade later. Few hospitals anywhere carry that kind of history in their walls.

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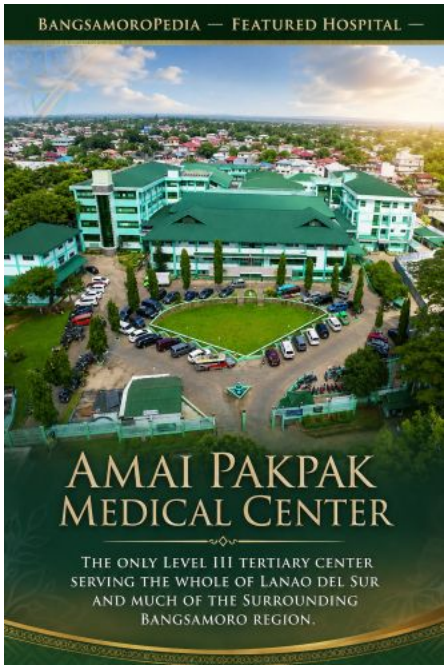
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Amai Pakpak Medical Center



Native Name

Sentrong Medikal ng Amai Pakpak

Location

Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), Philippines

Coordinates

8°00′17″N 124°17′01″E

Established

1903 (as a military hospital); 1910 (as a civilian hospital)

Former Name

Lanao General Hospital

Renamed

1995, pursuant to Republic Act No. 7943

Classification

Level III tertiary teaching and training hospital

Ownership

Department of Health (DOH), Republic of the Philippines

Bed Capacity

400 beds (authorized expansion to 800 beds under Republic Act No. 12207, signed May 8, 2025)

Specialties

Cardiology, oncology, general and orthopedic surgery, internal medicine,

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pediatrics, obstetrics-gynecology, radiology, laboratory services

Website

apmc.doh.gov.ph

Phone

(063) 876-0001

Email

info@apmc.doh.gov.ph

Category

Institution: Hospital / Medical Center

Notability

Mindanao's designated regional apex multi-specialty referral hospital, and the only Level III tertiary center serving the whole of Lanao del Sur and much of the surrounding Bangsamoro region.

Known For

Surviving two fires and the five-month Marawi siege of 2017, then rebuilding into a facility now offering open-heart surgery through its own Heart Institute.

Pull Quote

From a 25-bed cholera ward under a U.S. Army tent in 1910 to an 800-bed regional apex hospital a little over a century later, Amai Pakpak Medical Center has never really stopped rebuilding itself.

History

Early Origins (1903 to 1910)

The hospital's roots go back to 1903, when the United States Army's 27th Infantry Cavalry Division, under Captain John J. "Black Jack" Pershing, set up a military medical facility on a 20-hectare stretch of land then called Camp Marahui (later renamed Camp Keithley). It wasn't yet a hospital for the public, just a facility built to keep American soldiers alive during the occupation.

That changed in 1910. A cholera outbreak swept through the area, killing both U.S. military personnel and local residents, and Captain James Ames responded by organizing the facility into a proper 25-bed hospital, becoming its first chief in the process. That moment, arguably, is when Amai Pakpak's real story as a community hospital begins.

Lanao General Hospital Era (1910 to 1995)

For most of the twentieth century, the facility operated as Lanao General Hospital, a name locals eventually shortened to simply the "Public Hospital." Its bed capacity grew slowly but steadily over the decades: from 75 beds it was raised to 100 beds in 1992 through Republic Act No. 7217, then later doubled again as demand from the province kept climbing.

In 1984, the hospital was folded into the Integrated Provincial Health Office of Lanao del Sur as part of a broader integration program for the province's health system, a shift that placed it more firmly under local and provincial coordination even as it remained a national facility.

Conversion to Medical Center (1995)

The hospital's biggest institutional leap came on March 3, 1995, when President Fidel V. Ramos signed Republic Act No. 7943 into law. The measure, authored by the late Congressman Mamintal "Mike" Adiong Sr., renationalized the facility and elevated it from a general hospital into a full medical center, complete with the personnel, equipment, and infrastructure the new classification demanded.

It was this same law that gave the hospital its present name, honoring Amai Pakpak, a 19th-century Maranao military leader still remembered by the Maranao people as a symbol of resistance against Spanish colonial forces. Naming a modern medical institution after him wasn't a small gesture. It tied the hospital's identity directly to Maranao heritage and resilience, themes that would prove almost prophetic given everything the hospital would later go through.

The hospital's bed capacity kept pace with its growing status. Republic Act No. 11103, signed by President Rodrigo Duterte on October 30, 2018, raised the authorized bed count from 200 to 400, a threshold the DOH's own implementing rules (Administrative Order No. 2014-0028) had already anticipated in laying out standards for a

tertiary teaching and training hospital.

Fires and Reconstruction (2006, 2013)

Fire has twice threatened to undo decades of institutional growth. In 2006, a blaze triggered by a power overload destroyed the hospital's main building entirely. Recovery came with international help: the U.S. Joint Special Operations Task Force-Philippines funded and helped build a new facility, employing local workers and putting roughly $660,058 into the reconstruction.

Barely seven years later, on October 16, 2013, another fire tore through the century-old hospital. Operations resumed anyway, a pattern of quick recovery that would define APMC's next major test just four years later.

Marawi Siege (2017)

Nothing in the hospital's history compares to what happened during the Marawi siege, the five-month armed conflict that engulfed the city from May 23 to October 23, 2017. Militants affiliated with the Islamic State stormed the area around the hospital, and an ambulance driver was killed nearby. The battle zone around APMC saw such intense bombardment that roughly 95 percent of the structures within it were heavily damaged or destroyed outright. The hospital itself sustained losses estimated at ₱5,034,675 and was forced to close for the entire five months of fighting.

Recovery began almost as soon as the guns quieted. An eight-man assessment team inspected the hospital on June 7, 2017, to gauge whether it could reopen. Days later, on June 13, 2017, APMC's doctors, nurses, and administrative staff were redeployed to nearby district hospitals, evacuation centers, and the Philippine Red Cross, so patient care in the wider area wouldn't collapse while the main facility rebuilt. When APMC finally reopened, it didn't just resume normal operations. It went on to serve as one of the region's major facilities responding to the COVID-19 pandemic a few years later, treating patients from well beyond Lanao del Sur.

Description and Overview

Today, Amai Pakpak Medical Center is classified as a Level III tertiary teaching and training hospital under the Department of Health, and it functions as Mindanao's regional apex multi-specialty center. That means advanced services once only available in Manila or Cebu, cardiovascular surgery, cancer treatment, advanced endoscopy, are now offered right in Marawi.

As of 2026, the hospital runs on a 400-bed capacity, though Republic Act No. 12207, signed into law by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. on May 8, 2025, authorizes doubling that to 800 beds. The measure, sponsored by Lanao del Sur's 1st District Representative Ziaur-Rahman "Zia" Alonto Adiong, followed years of advocacy from hospital leadership, and it mandates that the hospital's services and facilities be upgraded in step with the added beds. APMC is also PhilHealth-accredited and offers Zero Balance Billing (ZBB) for ward care, which in practice means indigent patients can receive treatment without out-of-pocket costs.

Location and Geographic Context

APMC sits in Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, within BARMM, at coordinates 8°00′17″N 124°17′01″E. It's part of the urban core of what's often called the "Islamic City of Marawi," specifically in Barangay Datu Saber, accessible via Amai Pakpak Avenue. The hospital doesn't publish a precise street address on its official website, so anyone driving in for the first time is generally advised to just call ahead at (063) 876-0001 for directions.

Organization, Administration, and Governance

Ownership and Governance

APMC is owned and operated by the Department of Health, which makes it a DOH-retained hospital. In practical terms, this means the hospital answers directly to the national health department for funding and oversight, rather than to a local government unit, a structure that has helped it access national-level support during crises like the 2017 siege.

Legal Basis

The hospital's legal foundation runs through several pieces of legislation. Republic Act No. 7943 (1995) converted it from a general hospital into a medical center. Republic Act No. 11103 (2018) expanded its bed capacity to 400. And Republic Act No. 12207 (2025) authorizes the current push toward 800 beds. DOH Administrative Order No. 2014-0028 fills in the implementing details, setting standards for staffing, infrastructure, and administrative control appropriate to a tertiary teaching and training hospital.

Leadership

The hospital has been led since August 15, 2018, by Dr. Shalimar Sani-Rakiin, who took over as Medical Center Chief following the retirement of Dr. Amer A. Saber. Under her leadership, APMC has pushed through some of its most significant modern milestones, including the opening of the Heart Institute and the successful lobbying for the 800-bed expansion. The hospital's organizational structure includes departments for surgery, internal medicine, pediatrics, obstetrics-gynecology, radiology, and laboratory services, alongside specialized units like the Heart Institute and the Women & Children Protection Unit.

Functions, Services, and Programs

Medical Services

APMC's service list has grown considerably in recent years:

- **Cardiovascular Services**: The APMC Heart Institute opened its doors on August 11, 2023, under the leadership of Dr. Ali T. Macatanong, offering advanced cardiac care including coronary artery bypass graft (CABG) surgery. It was designed from the start as a regional referral center for complex cardiac cases, built with support and guidance from the Philippine Heart Center and Northern Mindanao Medical Center. In March 2025, PhilHealth-BARMM formally accredited the Heart Institute for the CABG Z Benefit Package, which covers up to ₱550,000 per patient and effectively removes the financial barrier to open-heart surgery for eligible members.
- **Oncology Services**: Cancer treatment is offered as part of the hospital's broader multi-specialty programs.
- **Advanced Endoscopy**: Endoscopic procedures are available for gastrointestinal and related conditions.
- **Surgical Services**: General surgery, orthopedic surgery, and other specialized procedures.
- **Internal Medicine**: Comprehensive adult medical care.
- **Pediatrics**: Child health services.
- **Obstetrics and Gynecology**: Maternal and reproductive health care.
- **Radiology and Imaging**: X-ray, ultrasound, CT scan, and other diagnostic services.
- **Laboratory Services**: Clinical testing and pathology.
- **HIV Treatment**: APMC operates as an HIV Treatment Center under the DOH network.

- **Women & Children Protection Unit (WCPU)**: Dedicated services for victims of violence and abuse.

Residency Training Programs

As a teaching and training hospital, APMC hosts residency programs in partnership with medical schools and professional organizations, including established training tracks within its anesthesia department and other clinical services, producing new physicians who often go on to serve elsewhere in the Bangsamoro region.

Public Health Programs

The hospital also participates in national health initiatives, among them Zero Balance Billing for indigent ward patients, the Malasakit Center program that consolidates financial and medical assistance under one roof, and full PhilHealth accreditation across multiple benefit packages, CABG surgery being the most recent addition.

Role and Significance

Regional Healthcare Hub

APMC functions as the primary referral hospital for Lanao del Sur and the surrounding provinces, taking on complex cases referred up from district hospitals and rural health units across Mindanao. That referral role is really what "regional apex center" means in practice: when smaller facilities can't handle a case, it usually ends up here.

Bangsamoro Context

Within BARMM, APMC carries weight beyond its medical charts. It provides advanced healthcare to a predominantly Muslim population that has, historically, faced real disparities in access to specialized care. Its reconstruction after the 2017 siege has come to symbolize the wider region's recovery and its determination to rebuild essential services rather than simply move on. And as a government hospital operating in an Islamic city, APMC has had to build cultural and religious sensitivity into how it serves patients, recognizing needs and traditions that a generic facility elsewhere in the country might not think to accommodate.

Pandemic Response

During the COVID-19 pandemic, APMC operated well beyond its normal capacity, treating patients from across Mindanao at a time when the health system was under enormous strain. Its reopening after the Marawi siege, just a few years earlier, positioned it as one of the region's most critical facilities when the pandemic hit.

Statistics and Key Facts

Indicator	Value
Year Established	1903 (military hospital); 1910 (civilian hospital)
Year Renamed	1995 (Republic Act No. 7943)
Bed Capacity	400 beds (authorized increase to 800 beds, Republic Act No. 12207, 2025)
Classification	Level III tertiary teaching and training hospital
Ownership	Department of Health (DOH), Republic of the Philippines
Location	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, BARMM
Coordinates	8°00′17″N 124°17′01″E
Phone	(063) 876-0001
Email	info@apmc.doh.gov.ph
Website	apmc.doh.gov.ph
Specialties	Cardiology, oncology, surgery, internal medicine, pediatrics, OB-GYN, radiology, laboratory
PhilHealth Accreditation	Yes, including the CABG Z Benefit Package (2025)
Zero Balance Billing	Yes (ward care)

Timeline of Major Events

Year	Event
1903	Established by the U.S. Army's 27th Infantry Cavalry Division under Captain John J. Pershing as a military hospital on 20 hectares of land in Camp Marahui.
1910	Converted into a 25-bed civilian hospital by Captain James Ames during a cholera outbreak; renamed Lanao General Hospital.
1984	Placed under the supervision of the Integrated Provincial Health Office of Lanao del Sur.
1992	Bed capacity raised to 100 beds under Republic Act No. 7217.
1995	Renationalized and converted into Amai Pakpak Medical Center through Republic Act No. 7943, signed by President Fidel V. Ramos on March 3.
2006	Main facility destroyed by fire; rebuilt with support from the U.S. Joint Special Operations Task Force-Philippines.
2013	A second fire damages the hospital on October 16; operations resume shortly after.
2017	Marawi siege (May 23 to October 23) causes ₱5,034,675 in losses; hospital closed for five months.
2018	Dr. Shalimar Sani-Rakiin installed as Medical Center Chief on August 15; bed capacity raised to 400 under Republic Act No. 11103, signed October 30.
2020 to 2021	Serves beyond capacity during the COVID-19 pandemic, treating patients from across Mindanao.
2023	APMC Heart Institute opens on August 11.
2024	House Bill No. 10258, seeking to raise bed capacity to 800, is filed in Congress.
2025	Republic Act No. 12207, raising bed capacity to 800, is signed by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. on May 8; PhilHealth-BARMM accredits the Heart Institute for the CABG Z Benefit Package on March 3.

Legacy and Continuing Impact

Amai Pakpak Medical Center has become something of a case study in institutional persistence. From a 25-bed tent hospital during a cholera outbreak in 1910 to a DOH-retained Level III tertiary teaching and training hospital more than a century later, APMC has weathered fires, armed conflict, and a global pandemic without ever permanently closing its doors to the people who depend on it.

Its rebuilding after the 2017 siege, and its frontline role during the COVID-19 pandemic that followed not long after, say as much about the region's resilience as they do about the hospital itself. The opening of the Heart Institute in 2023 and the PhilHealth accreditation for CABG surgery in 2025 mark the hospital's clearest steps yet toward becoming a genuine regional apex center, one capable of keeping patients in Mindanao for procedures that once meant a flight to Manila.

As BARMM continues to develop, APMC remains one of its most important pieces of public infrastructure, a place that trains the region's next generation of doctors and nurses while still serving as the last stop for the most difficult cases in Lanao del Sur and beyond.

See Also

- Marawi City, the Islamic City of Marawi, capital of Lanao del Sur and site of the 2017 siege
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)

- Department of Health (Philippines)
- Amai Pakpak, the 19th-century Maranao military leader after whom the hospital is named
- Siege of Marawi (2017)
- PhilHealth
- Lanao del Sur

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